

The Keys of Fasting and Worship

The Lord was speaking about a place in Him that becomes available as soon as the Holy Spirit removes what stands in the way. It is a place of worship that comes when He replaces one kind of fellowship with another.

I am understanding more and more of my prayer language, sometimes almost sentence by sentence. I cannot do that all the time, but if I could operate it whenever I chose, it would no longer be the Spirit's operation.

One day in this auditorium, groups of families were praying. Some had camped here all day with their children. When those children grow older and someone asks their earliest memory of church, they may answer, "Camping at church all day while my parents prayed." You do not hear much of that anymore.

I had prayed most of the day and was walking among the groups. As I came near one group, I began understanding what they prayed in tongues. Then I passed another group and understood them too. Each prayed a different facet of the same essential message. I also understood my own tongue between the groups, and it carried the same prayer.

The Holy Ghost was praying for a fellowship and relationship with God that they presently held with other things.

That is edification. Jude describes those who are sensual, not having the Spirit, then says:

But ye, beloved, building up yourselves on your most holy faith, praying in the Holy Ghost...

By praying in the Holy Ghost, you build yourself above a sense-dominated walk.

Turn to Matthew 17. We will consider fasting, not as a complete teaching, but in the light God brought it forward to me.

On the ninth day of a fast, we held several meetings about receiving grace for change, trading our weaknesses for God's strength. A highly anointed friend helped minister to a prayer line. As the line ended, the Holy Spirit told me to get in it.

My friend was still several people away when a gentle breeze passed over me. My spirit became so light that I thought I might rise, but instead I went to the floor. There God told me, and I will be kind in repeating it, "You really know nothing about worship."

Because I was fasting, my mind immediately protested: "What about fasting?"

He answered, "Fasting cannot give you what worship gives, and worship cannot give you what fasting gives."

I did not fully understand, but I knew I needed to listen. I ended the fast because sustained worship would require energy, and this was different from either fasting or praying in tongues.

During long periods of tongues, I usually sit, lie down, or walk and pray quietly. Years ago, I stopped straining my vocal cords. We are speaking to God, so whispering or shouting does not alter the content.

Some speak of a special "warring tongue," but the same Spirit-created prayer is expressed whether loudly or softly. The faith required is simply enough to let the Holy Spirit create the language in your spirit and pass it through you so your human spirit does the praying.

I learned to pray quietly in cheap motel rooms after people next door pounded on the wall. People sometimes arrive here marching, shouting, and rasping in a supposed warring tongue. After a while, they lie on the floor whispering like everyone else. Trust me, the prayer still edifies.

Tongues uses little physical energy. You will not lose much weight by exercising your tongue. Worship, however, demanded sustained concentration of my soul.

I entered my dark, soundproof radio room with no music, no worship recording, and no distraction, just God and me. I intended to learn how to worship Him.

During the first several days, I repeatedly discovered that my mouth had said, "I love You," for fifteen minutes while my mind wandered down the street solving problems. Lip service is easy. In corporate worship, music supplies emotional momentum, and lyrics supply thought. A person can participate outwardly while the soul remains elsewhere.

My soul is mind, will, intellect, and emotions. With the body I contact physical things. With the spirit I contact God. With the soul I communicate with other people through accumulated knowledge, decision, and emotion.

In tongues, my spirit immediately contacts God with thoughts originated by the Holy Spirit. I am safe because I do not direct the content. I may imagine I am praying for a new car while the Holy Spirit is actually building me above the habit of yelling at my wife.

Worship required me to offer the whole soul. Every attribute of mind, will, intellect, and emotion had to learn respect for Jesus as Son of God and King.

Jesus is my Confidant, best Friend, answer in trouble, high tower, shelter, and glorified Brother. But when I enter the presence of my God and King, I will observe protocol. I will not give Him lip service while the rest of me wanders away.

Earthly ambassadors observe protocol before kings. In some courts, they do not look at the king until invited. In others, they bring a suitable gift. One must not insult a ruler with a careless offering.

There is one gift Christ desires from you that He cannot receive another way: you. He wants you to offer yourself.

This required energy. The first hour was familiar, but beyond it the minutes stretched. I entered dry places and saw parts of myself I did not like. Still I continued.

Within a week or two, I entered repentance so deep that it turned me inside out. I could not cry or repent any more intensely. I had experienced something similar only after extended fasting, when I described the Lord as kissing me with compassion.

That compassion changed how I saw and treated people, what I endured from them, and how long I remained when others wanted me to abandon someone in trouble.

Isaiah 58 speaks of clothing the naked, feeding the hungry, receiving the outcast, and not hiding from one's own flesh.

The day you decide to fast is the day you decide to stop hiding from whatever in your flesh does not care. Churches may wheel sick people in and out year after year while indifference and complacency remain untouched.

At Fort Payne, I met a youth leader born with growths in his ears. Multiple operations removed the growths and finally the eardrum. He had attended Baptist and Pentecostal churches for years believing deafness was his cross and that God could heal him if He wished.

I asked whether it was right to attend church continually and keep the condition. He said no. Three minutes later, he heard. God had to restore the eardrum itself.

Fasting attacks the indifference that tolerates such bondage. It crucifies whatever in the flesh refuses to care.

My deepest repentance after long fasts consistently concerned other people. If a spiritual experience produces cockiness and self-exaltation, it is not God. God makes you a servant, then lowers you further until you will not even bruise a flax.

God's love is perfected as we love one another. You cannot leave people behind and claim to pursue Him. Once you love God, He introduces you to His greatest earthly love: people. The vertical relationship must become horizontal.

Worship brought me to that kind of repentance in less than two weeks, but with a different kind of strength than fasting produced.

Public music opens the emotions, and a skillfully written song supplies the words. Yet someone can sing, "Oh, how I love Jesus," while planning how to injure a person across the aisle.

That is lip service. You will not become a strong corporate worshiper while placing all responsibility on the worship leader to pull you into God's presence within thirty minutes.

A good private worshiper enters corporate worship already prepared. You may worship so fully that the leader can lower his hands and let the congregation continue.

Jesus warned against vain repetition, but if repetition can be vain, it can also be true. True repetition says what God says until faith receives it.

The Father knows what we need before we pray. Therefore Jesus gave the Lord's Prayer as the protocol and prerequisite of petition:

Our Father which art in heaven, Hallowed be thy name.

We enter with worship.

Thy kingdom come. Thy will be done in earth, as it is in heaven.

We consecrate ourselves to His will.

Give us this day our daily bread.

Provision accompanies seeking the kingdom.

We forgive those who trespass against us so the Father can forgive us, and we avoid the enemy's traps. Without these realities in our prayer life, we might as well fold the petition and return it to the shelf.

The visitation concerning fasting and worship was so strong that I committed to obey. God directed me into series fasting, a pattern of certain days fasting followed by certain days eating, rather than one continuous prophetic-length fast.

As soon as I surrendered, someone brought confirmation through a video about a missionary in Mexico who had entered a creative-miracle ministry through persistent fasting.

Early in his work, a child drowned and God told him to raise the child. He ran from the experience. After recovering, he determined never to run again. He gathered every Scripture concerning raising the dead and meditated day and night, worshiped God, and fasted relentlessly over several years.

He would complete a long fast, recover enough to begin again, and continue. Another minister, devastated by his wife's death and desperate for God's reality, completed repeated forty-day fasts. After the sixth, an angel appeared, and miracles began flowing through his ministry.

The missionary later held his adopted son, dead for a day and a half, and called life back until the child began breathing and rose.

He eventually adopted a continuing rhythm of fasting and eating. His traveling team followed a discipline of three days eating and three days fasting, with an extended fast each January. He reportedly saw twenty-two resurrections personally, while the team witnessed around two hundred.

After pastoring a prayer center, I can tell you that the greater miracle may be persuading fifty or sixty people to maintain that discipline together.

The only reason a ministry cannot profoundly affect its city may be that its people do not truly want the cost. God told me the final stretch would require all the keys working together.

After the visitation, I asked God to explain the difference. Romans 8 provided the answer:

And if Christ be in you, the body is dead because of sin; but the Spirit is life because of righteousness.

If Christ is in you, this positional truth belongs to you. Your body has been declared dead to dominion, while your human spirit is alive through Christ's righteousness and seated with Him.

Fasting by an unregenerate religious person produces only hunger because there is no spiritual position to enforce. In a born-again believer, fasting enforces the body's declared death as far as its dominance over the spirit is concerned.

Matthew 17 records the disciples asking why they could not cast out a demon. Jesus answered, "Because of your unbelief," then said:

Howbeit this kind goeth not out but by prayer and fasting.

The "kind" at issue was the subtle unbelief they did not know they possessed. Fasting does not move God or make Him more willing. It deals with the flesh where unbelief has built a ceiling over the spirit.

Authority does not increase because someone shouts at a demon. Once, people struggled to deliver a woman and finally asked me to help. I knelt, cupped my hands around her ears, and quietly commanded, "Come out in Jesus' name." The spirit left.

They repeatedly asked what profound words I had used. The words were simple. The issue was not vocal force but the authority released through faith.

A believer may pray year after year while flesh keeps ministry and faith below a ceiling. Tongues brings revelation about what deals with that flesh. Fasting pushes the flesh beneath the spirit's rightful place.

As prayer raises the spirit and fasting lowers fleshly dominance, the spirit eventually breaks above the ceiling. Then what is already within the spirit can flow outward.

If a Baptist filled chiefly with love for souls fasts, that soul-winning nature may come forward powerfully. Whatever has been developed in the spirit is what fasting unseals.

Fasting did not move God. It destroyed the ceiling preventing the spirit's authority from operating.

The three keys can therefore be distinguished:

- Praying in tongues is the Holy Spirit fellowshiping with and edifying the human spirit through revelation.
- Worship is the human spirit communing directly with God.
- Fasting enforces the body's declared death and breaks fleshly dominance over the spirit.

Alongside these are assimilating, meditating, confessing, and practicing the Word. All the keys belong together.

Long fasts can be good. I once became so hungry for God that bodily hunger seemed irrelevant. My wife feared I would damage myself because I became extremely thin.

During such seasons I encountered demons, received visitations from God, and experienced an anointing so strong that people flew backward when I prayed. A demon once spoke weakly from someone who had slid several feet, "Do I have to come out?"

I was so surprised that I answered, "Why, yes. Come out!"

Miracles occurred, and I thought I had arrived. Then the anointing lifted, and I returned to conduct I had sworn never to repeat, not scandalous sin, but behavior inconsistent with a fully surrendered walk.

God said that when the anointing returned in fullness, it would remain. I now see portions of it from time to time.

Jesus' forty-day fast closed the door on Satan at the threshold of His ministry. Yet fasting did not replace grace. Christ has already given us His standing.

He that spared not his own Son...how shall he not with him also freely give us all things?

Do not insult God by imagining hunger persuades Him to do what the cross already provided. Fasting moves us into position to receive what He is already doing.

People sometimes spend a year preparing psychologically for a forty-day fast, fight through family, work, and demonic pressure, then expect to emerge clothed in glory and immediately rival famous healing ministries.

When that does not happen, they reject fasting. But God was never the reluctant party being moved. If forty days did not sufficiently break the flesh's ceiling, more change may be required.

At the end of my first long fast, manifestations actually seemed to decrease. I felt that after sacrificing preaching opportunities and income to seek God, He had stopped everything. I nearly lost heart, but I knew something deeper was occurring.

I recovered and entered another fast. One fast did not complete the work in me. After two and a half extended fasts, I reached peace that delivered me from four years of torment. The devil thought he had me, but he did not.

A forty-day fast is valuable if one remains prepared to continue in whatever wise pattern is needed. With fasting, the issue is how long transformation takes, not a magical number of days.

After a long fast, recover adequately. Series fasting may then mean one or two days fasting followed by one or two days eating, repeated consistently. This pattern can be maintained while the flesh's atmosphere changes.

How will you know change is occurring? Things will begin to move.

Your spirit communes with God through worship. The Holy Spirit imparts revelation daily through tongues. Your soul is given to meditation and assimilation of the Word. Fasting continually deals with the flesh.

When spirit, soul, and body are brought into that order, your city is in trouble.